flew out to Los Angeles to meet Jones. It was February and Los Angeles was reeling under an unprecedented rainstorm that had wreaked havoc and caused scores of deaths in the city. Ratan reminisces: ‘There were these mudslides and rain and so on. He [Jones] was ill and was staying at his girlfriend’s [Elaine Sewell, whom Jones later married] place. He had some flu or something.’ Seeing the unusual condition prevailing in the city, Ratan was not even sure if Jones would meet him. But to his surprise, ‘I got taken into his bedroom, and he asked me how my thesis was,’ Ratan remembers. ‘So, I got the photographs of my thesis and showed it to him. He looked at it and asked, “Will you work for me?” I said I’d love that. He said, “Well, then start tomorrow.”’ Ratan was euphoric. He could hardly believe what he had just heard.

Even five and a half decades on, Ratan can hardly contain his smile when he recalls what he did after he was offered the job. ‘So the next morning he let me have his car, and I went around and found an apartment. I moved in my stuff and went to Cornell to stop my other stuff from being moved to India. Then I came back to Los Angeles and joined him.’ Thus started Ratan’s American Dream. He had just landed an assignment with one of the pioneering design firms in America. Jones had formed a partnership with Frederick Earl Emmons in 1950 to found Jones & Emmons. Their partnership gained fame for its inventive designs. Both Jones and Emmons were quick to spot and appreciate the talent in their new Indian recruit. They were ‘particularly nice’ to him, Ratan recalls.

Ratan not only worked hard but also stayed back and put in extra hours to meet exacting deadlines. This gave him a few more dollars in overtime. His dedication and talent made him a natural choice for inclusion in the prestigious projects that the firm was undertaking. One such project was erecting a building in the Mojave Desert, southeast of California, to house-test jigs for Atlas rockets, which were used as Intercontinental Ballistic Missiles (ICBMs).

First Love

Interestingly, during this period, Ratan found his first true love too. She was nineteen-year-old Carolyn Emmons, the daughter of Frederick Emmons. Her father introduced her to Ratan. She said that she was attracted to Ratan at first sight. Her parents were also very fond of him. Her father ‘loved’